

Five Useful Open Source Tools for Windows Systems Administrators



Much of the work that Windows systems administrators do is tedious, repetitive, boring and time consuming. Thankfully, there are open source tools available that can greatly assist them in these mundane tasks. A selection of these tools is discussed in this article.

Anyone trying to install new software on a Windows desktop or laptop, by clicking on the .exe file, often gets a new window asking whether it should be *Run as Administrator*. Often, you click on 'Yes' and go ahead with the installation. But have you ever wondered who that administrator actually is and what role a Windows sys admin plays? If you haven't given it a thought, then there is much you need to learn about.

Windows systems administrators take care of the configuration and reliable functioning of Windows computer systems or servers. They not only create user accounts, run *Defrag* once in a while or clear out caches to make sure there aren't any viruses, but also ensure that the performance, resources, uptime and security of the Windows system meets the user's needs without exceeding budget limits. They can troubleshoot, acquire, install or even upgrade different Windows components, train or supervise staff and provide routine automation in order to meet the needs of different users.

Let's have a look at the various significant responsibilities that a Windows sys admin assumes:

1. Monitoring and maintaining the performance of the Windows system

2. Setting up and maintaining Windows user accounts
3. Creating different file systems
4. Monitoring Windows network communication
5. Software installation
6. Updating the system as soon as a new version of Windows comes out
7. Framing the backup creation and recover policy
8. Implementing different policies for the use of the network and computer system
9. Setting up security policies for users
10. Managing Windows passwords and identity

How open source tools can aid Windows sys admins

Most of us want to avoid various manual tasks as much as possible by making tools do these tasks for us. Similarly, Windows sys admins try to use various tools to perform different sets of actions, which help them to get these tasks done faster, with greater accuracy and fewer errors. At the same time, sys admins cannot be dependent only on tools for all their tasks, as there are certain actions that need their intervention. Open source tools can assist Windows sys admins in a range of tasks, some of which are listed below.